Amrik Singh, jailed under TADA (Terrorist and Disruptive Activities) Prevention Act, gave an analogy indicative of his reactions: 'It posed a big problem, and put a man under great stress, when he had some jaggery and he was asked to describe its taste. What this course of *Vipassana* did to a person cannot truly be described. It must be experienced and only then would one come to know of its benefits and the complete transformation of personality it could bring about.'

Even a large section of the administrative staff underwent this meditation course. The results brought about a marked change in their attitude towards the inmates. An atmosphere of humaneness pervaded the prison campus, and the aura of fear seemed to have disappeared. Even the staffers' wives maintained that after their husbands completed these courses their domestic life had changed for the better.

At the end of one such course, Kiran, in her address to the inmates, pointed out: 'Our staff has also undergone this course. One of the superintendents of the four jails, Tarseem Kumar, a few of the deputy superintendents, Subhash Sharma, V. P. Garg, M. S. Rittu and Sunil Gupta, as also wardens and assistant superintendents have undertaken this course. So this is not just an opportunity for you or for us separately. This is an opportunity which we can partake of together, collectively. This is an opportunity for all of us to become one big family and to learn and to get to know ourselves together.'

On 4 April 1994, a remarkable occurrence took place in Jail 4 of Tihar, where over 1000 male prisoners and 60 women prisoners, separately, undertook the *Vipassana* course. Never had so many prisoners committed themselves voluntarily to the regimen of a course that forbade them to interact with each other for a period of eleven long days and in which they had to take a vow of silence. Such a phenomenon had never been witnessed in prisons. In monasteries, yes; in convents, yes; in ashrams, yes; but in prisons, never.

The head of the Vipassana Mission, Guru S. N. Goenka, conducted the programme himself. In a very patient, gentle and endearing tone, he addressed himself to the group of women *Vipassanis* on the third day of the course:

> You are breathing … you are concentrating on your breath … as it goes over the area between your upper lip and your nostril … feel it, feel it … around the outside of your nostril … up, along the insides of the nose …. The breath comes out … feel it … feel it … constant awareness … be aware … feel it … now. Today, you are aware of the breath … as it rubs against the skin … as it rubs …. it rubs …. Do you feel it? … Do you feel the slight irritation? … Concentrate on it … concentrate … it will go … no? …. Stop breathing for a couple of seconds … breathe again …. Come back to that spot … it will go. This happens with every breath … friction will create irritation …. But today you are aware of it. Be aware. Slowly, gradually, you will learn to transfer your concentration and awareness to other functions of the body. They are all happening, always, without fail, but you are not aware. Now, you will be.
>
> This is what *Vipassana* is. It is not religion. It is only awareness, of yourself, of your mind; it only leads to better conduct, better understanding, better behaviour. You see, *Vipassana* can be seen as surgery. It is surgery of the mind. It is a dharma, a code of conduct, right conduct, moral conduct.

With rapt attention, the *Sadhaks* (meditators) listened to this almost hypnotic discourse. Guru Goenka asked them to state any problems they may have had.

Several voices were heard. One was that of a Sikh prisoner. She was used to performing her *paath*